

The pitch — variants

One mechanism, bent to fit the room. Two things never change.

ALWAYS FALL BACK TO THIS

“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. A member has to vouch for you to get in — and if you behave badly, they go too.”

THE MECHANISM A member vouches you in, and stays answerable for you. Break the rules and you both go.

THE CLOSE “Would you actually use this?” · “Who are the three Manhattanites you’d vouch for?” Ask the second one every time, even when it has gone badly.

Part 1 — by scenario

Where you are, not who they are.

“So what are you up to at the moment?” — the passing version

“I’ve built an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. You can only get in if a member vouches for you — and if you misbehave, they’re out too.”

NOTE Eight seconds, then stop. If they want more they’ll ask, and the asking is the signal.

They asked a second question — the full version

“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Apartments, furniture, whatever you need. A member has to vouch for you to get in, and they stay responsible for you: break the rules and you’re both out. So people are careful about who they bring in. Think about your group chat. Someone posts that they’ve got a spare room going, and you trust it straight away, because you know exactly who you’re dealing with. That’s the feeling I’m building.”

Across a counter — the shop, the café, the super

“I run a members-only site for New Yorkers — apartments, furniture, that sort of thing. You have to be vouched in by someone already on it. I’m putting the first ten people together now.”

NOTE Thirty seconds between customers. Casual, no product talk.

On the phone, or a voice note

“You know how if someone in your group chat says they’ve got a room going, you just trust it? I’ve built a site that works like that. Invite-only, everyone vouched in by a member — and if you break the rules, the person who vouched for you goes too.”

NOTE They can’t see your face, so lead with the picture rather than the definition.

Being introduced by someone else

“Invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Everyone’s vouched in by a member, and that member’s on the hook if it goes wrong. [Friend]’s seen it — he can tell you whether it’s any good.”

NOTE Keep it short and give the friend a job.

Text, DM, or a reply in a group chat

“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers — everyone’s vouched in by a member, and the member’s on the hook for them.”

NOTE One line. No paragraph.

When it isn’t the moment

“Long story — short version is it’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers, everyone vouched in. I’ll send you the proper version.”

NOTE Wrong room, wrong energy, or the fourth time today. Park it honestly rather than doing a bad version — then actually send it.

Part 2 — by person

The pitch cards give you an angle line for each of the twelve tracker types. This is shallower on purpose: the opener itself, bent six ways, for when you haven’t typed them yet.

The sceptic, the businessman

“Nobody actually uses Craigslist or Marketplace here any more. They ask their group chats. I’ve built the group-chat version and made it enforceable: a member vouches you in, and if you break the rules they go too.”

NOTE The Marwan case. Lead with the pain, never the product, and get the enforcement in early — that’s what he’s testing for.

The practical New Yorker — renting, moving, hunting

“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Everything on it comes from someone another member put themselves on the line for. No scams, no ghosts, no strangers.”

The socially connected one

“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Getting in means someone vouches for you and stakes their own membership on you. Turns out that makes people behave.”

NOTE Do not reach for velvet-rope language. The interesting part here is the stake, not the door.

The older, settled local

“It’s a private listings site for New Yorkers — apartments, furniture, the useful things. Members only, and each member is answerable for whoever they bring in. The first ten set the standard for everyone after.”

NOTE Slower and plainer. Lead with standard, not novelty.

The supply side — landlord, buildings, shop

“It’s an invite-only listings site. Every enquiry you’d get comes from someone a member vouched in and stays answerable for. You can see who brought them.”

NOTE NEVER describe the membership by the type of person in this conversation. Conduct, not type.
(Fair-Housing_Research_v1.md)

The one who wants to know why it works

“Every marketplace bolts trust on at the end — reviews, badges, dispute resolution. I built the trust first: a member vouches you in and carries the risk of you. There’s a French site running on that one rule with two million members.”

NOTE Finance, tech, media. The design, then the proof.

Part 3 — written variants

Same content, different room. Nothing here is a template to send unread.

The invitation — the decided version

Manhattanite is an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Apartments, furniture, things worth passing on. The same stuff you'd find on any classifieds site.

The difference is who's on it. A member has to vouch for you before you can join, and they stay responsible for you afterwards. If you break the rules, you're both removed. So people are careful and considered about who they bring in.

Think about your group chat. Someone mentions they've got a spare room going and you trust it straight away, because you know exactly who you're dealing with. That's what I'm building, at the scale of a city.

It's small on purpose. I'm choosing the first ten members by hand, and I'd like you to be one of them.

Text or WhatsApp

Been building something — an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Apartments, furniture, that sort of thing, except you can only join if a member vouches for you, and they stay answerable for you afterwards.

I'm picking the first ten by hand and I want you in. Free, takes a minute. Can I send you the link?

Someone who's already heard about it from a friend

Short version: it's an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers — apartments, furniture, whatever people need. You can only join if a member vouches for you, and if you break the rules you're both removed, so people are careful about who they bring in.

[Friend] can vouch for you if you want in. There are ten of us to start with.

Writing to a friend of a member (second degree)

[Member] suggested I get in touch. I've built a private listings site for New Yorkers — apartments, furniture, things worth passing on — where every member is vouched in by another member who stays answerable for them.

He's offered to vouch for you, which is the only way in. It's small on purpose: ten members to begin with. Worth a look?

Part 4 — the questions that actually come back

The pitch is rarely the hard part. These are.

"Is it free?"	"Free to join, free to browse. Paying to post comes much later, and membership stays free."
"How many people are on it?"	"Ten, to start with, picked by hand. That's the point rather than the problem."
"Who else is on it?"	"I'll ask them before I start using their names — same courtesy you'd get."
"What if someone I vouch for behaves badly?"	"We'd both be off it. Which is exactly why I'm asking you and not everyone."

“Can I invite people?”	“That’s the whole engine. Three names is what I usually ask for.”
“Is it just Manhattan?”	“Manhattan first. I’d rather it were dense than big.”
“Is this a startup?”	“It’s not a startup-startup. It costs about ten dollars a month to run, there’s no investor, and I’m picking the first ten members by hand. Closer to a members’ club than a company.”
“So it’s Craigslist?”	Agree, then turn — never resist the comparison. “Exactly, except you can’t get on it unless someone puts themselves on the line for you.”
They’ve gone blank	Drop the definition, give them the picture. “Think about your group chat. Someone’s got a spare room going and you trust it straight away, because you know who you’re dealing with.”
They ask something you don’t know	“I don’t know yet. I’ll find out and tell you.” That answer is on-brand. Making one up is not.

BEFORE YOU WALK IN — SIXTY SECONDS, NO MORE

1. Which scenario is this? Which person? 2. Say the opener once, under your breath. 3. Decide the tailored ask — what would this person list or look for first? 4. Remember the close. Both questions, every time.

The decision this is built on lives in [Manhattanite_One-Line-Pitch_v2.md](#). Next revision after the first five conversations.